On his return from Amritsar, Deshmukh conveyed his impression of the visit to his joint secretary (internal security), an IPS officer, Jyotish Pandey, who mentioned that the outward calm was deceptive and there were undercurrents that were causing anxiety in the home ministry. Pandey's concern mainly emanated from the Congress party's activities following their loss of power in Punjab. According to Deshmukh, 'The reading in the Home Ministry was that the Congress was creating a monster who would one day devour the Congress itself.' [10]

Unfortunately, Punjab was not to remain a 'haven of prosperity and peace' for long. Political opportunism and short-term electoral gains overtook considerations of national interest and the need to maintain religious harmony, peace, prosperity and stability. A community that had played a significant part in India's freedom struggle and in providing food security through the Green Revolution, in addition to giving the country some of its best soldiers and sportspersons and was on its way to a significant industrial growth, became a victim of cold-blooded political calculations.

The developments in Punjab after January 1980 also adversely impacted the activities of the Sikh diaspora.

My Return to Headquarters

On my return to headquarters in October 1979, as per normal practice for the R&AW officers returning from foreign assignments, I reported to Gauri Shankar Bajpai (1953 IPS Uttar Pradesh), who was responsible for manning and managing the R&AW's foreign stations and sensitive operational work. Bajpai had already been earmarked to join the ministry of external affairs on promotion as joint secretary (personnel) to look after security and vigilance-related matters of the MEA, including those of Indian missions abroad.

Soon after completion of the formalities related to my return to headquarters, Bajpai told me that Suntook wanted me to take charge of Bajpai's post the same day in order to enable him to join the MEA. This came as somewhat of a pleasant surprise to me. Bajpai